

we have to sacrifice some things that we love to keep what we love most. Seeking these alternatives also gives room to try new things and learn about others outside the context of our ingrained habits.

Spending within our friendships also has a lot to do with our levels of confidence in what we bring to the table. Recognizing your own worth, uniqueness, and what you have to offer will save you from spending with friends in order to fit in or gain approval. I'm talking to all my girlies who feel the internal pressure to pay someone's way, treat others to lunch, or can't show up without a host gift. Those things are fine, but not when they come from a place of perceived expectations or believing you must spend money because you alone aren't enough. You are valuable apart from what you do for or spend on others. And your generosity can be measured and executed in a way that doesn't put unnecessary strain on your finances. Being generous can also look like giving of your time, a listening ear, and maybe even a gift sourced from home if you don't want to show up somewhere empty-handed. In whatever ways you choose to give, know that it's yours to decide how you want to spend your resources, and this should be done out of desire, not compulsion.

We *can* have the best of both worlds: kindness to our financial selves and cultivated friendships.

Of course, not everyone is going to be on the same page as us or value similar things, and that's okay! We can only be responsible for ourselves, say what works, speak our needs, and invite others in. What our friends choose is not up to us, nor do we know what's best for them. But when it comes to what works for us, we can be clear, kind, and communicative. Whenever possible, we can be the ones making the plans, offering fun free suggestions, and letting our friends in on the financial parameters we've set for ourselves so they can adjust and respond how they want. We can be the change we want to see with the friends we already have.

Take for instance group outings, trips, or events—it's best to set expectations ahead of time and have some transparent conversations *before* any money gets spent. I (Jill) take at least one friend trip a year, and before deciding where we will go, we have a check-in on the total amount of money that everyone is willing to spend. We take the lowest number and work our travel plans accordingly.

For events like bridal or baby showers and bachelorette parties where we are highly involved in the planning and execution, the same principles